

Ear Mufflers

Agent 001 goes hunting for good headphones—something not many of us tend to bother about!

After a long, tiring day, many of us at Digit like to relax listening to music. The iPod is the device of choice for many, but there are few of us who have MP3-playing cell phones. However, no matter which of these devices one buys, the earphones or headphones turn out to be the spoilsports.

In fact, I recently upgraded my cell phone to a Nokia E61, and was horrified at the single earpiece Nokia had bundled along with it. That forced me to look for better earphones, and this began my window-shopping for all kinds of earphones / headphones available in the market.

Of course, when it comes to headphones and earphones, there is just too much on offer, so I've broken my experiences into categories—for PCs, you have to choose between headphones with microphones and standalone headphones. Earphones for MP3 players, cell phones, etc., are a completely different category.

Headphones/earphones are designed for specific situations, so when buying a pair, make a decision based on your needs. For example, a pair of headphones for a TV set can sound terrible with MP3 players or portable CD players because of the impedance difference.

A word of caution before I proceed: don't use headphones for too long at high volumes—that can cause *permanent* damage to your ears!

The majority of us use headsets with our PCs. These have large over-the-ear phones and an integrated microphone. iBall, Intex, Frontech, and Zebronics are some of the notable vendors offering such solutions. The typical price range is between Rs 500 and Rs 1,500. The top models generally have bigger earpieces and better padding, but don't offer too much more in terms of sound quality. All this is fine for video-conferencing, Skype calls and IM-ing, but for music... think again. Personally, I'd rather opt for a separate headphone and microphone solution.

You can get a decent set of Philips headphones for Rs 800, and a Rs 150 microphone for your computer. However, if you want a quality headset, Plantronics is the name you should be looking for. They have good headsets, which are expensive but comfortable. The basic models cost between

Rs 1,500 and Rs 2,000, and as more features come in, the price goes up.

I found that headphones come in all sizes and price brackets. Entry-level ones cost as little as Rs 250, and the best pair I saw would set you back by a whopping Rs 40,000! These are, of course, audiophile-grade. Philips has been a long-time player in the headphone market, and every music shop sells them (yes, Planet M too). The basic ones retail at around Rs 250, and are designed for low-impedance devices such as cassette recorders, MP3 players, and portable CD players—not for TVs or music systems. Moving up the ladder, you can get headphones for TVs and amplifiers for about Rs 800—the Philips set I mentioned earlier.

If you want something better, opt for Sony or Panasonic headphones, which are readily available at any electronics shop—they're priced between Rs 1,500 and 2,000. Headphones from Sennheiser, Grado, AKG, and others are in a different league altogether, and some of their low-end models are available in India—only in places selling imported goods, of course. In Mumbai, you will find these brands at Alfa or Heera-Paana. Expect to pay a premium for them!

As far as earphones are concerned, you need to be very careful when choosing. Almost every MP3 player we've tested thus far comes bundled with shoddy earphones—even models from big brands. Since they are plugged directly into your ear, they can do much more harm than headphones can. Most shops will offer "Sony" earphones for Rs 100, and these are patently fake—original Sony earphones will cost at least Rs 500.

I think the ones that are bundled with the Sony Ericsson "W" range of phones are decently comfortable and offer good sound quality. They are called "Fontopia", and I recommend them for all Sony Ericsson phones and MP3 players—about Rs 1,500. Sennheiser has also recently launched earphones, and you can be sure that these are good.

When it comes to Nokia cell phones, except for the N91, all the others require an adapter. Any Nokia phone with a pop-port will require the Nokia AD-15 adapter to connect a standard 3.5 mm headphone set. This will allow you to connect any pair of earphones, and you won't be limited to a Nokia pair.

For my new phone, I chose to buy the Nokia adapter and Philips headphones—a temporary solution till I get myself a Sennheiser set! ■

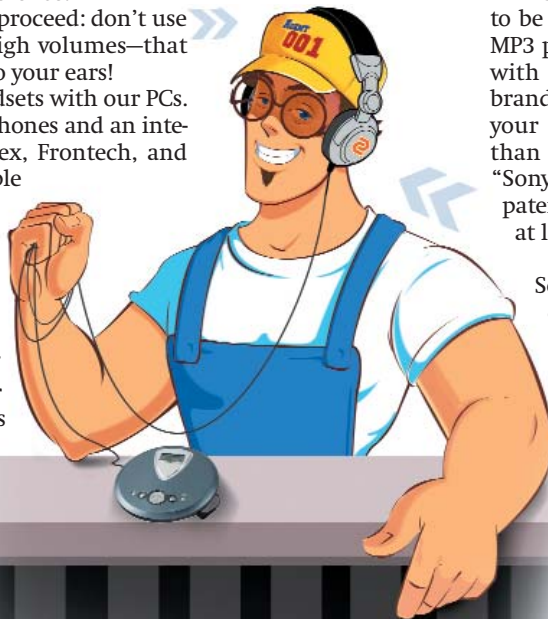


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